

Ancient Persia and Ancient Greece: The Antithesis of Monarchial and Non-Monarchial Systems

Introduction

Ancient civilizations teach us about our forefathers, what we can learn from their mistakes, the lessons we can implement in our lives, and much more. The civilizations we study are not always perfect; each has its perks and flaws. When we talk about monarchy, oftentimes a sort of dictatorship government comes to mind, which clouds our judgment to dive into the bigger picture and to ask the questions that are critical, but essential to understand. While a non-monarchial system may sound fair and liberal, it doesn't show why the government chose this type of ruling in its empire. This paper delves deeper into the Persian and Greek governing systems, the socio-political aspect, the philosophy of their choosing, as well as the role and position of women due to this type of governance.

Sociopolitical Aspect

An absolute monarchy ruled the Persian Empire. From 550 BCE, King Cyrus expanded the Persian empire, especially the Achaemenid empire, and established a monarchy. From then on, the king's words were considered as law themselves. No one had power over the king. The idea of a universal empire came to the minds of the rulers. There is a long history that stretches the far as the Assyrian as well as Achaemenid empires, claiming to be rulers of the universal empire (Bang & Kołodziejczyk, 2012). The system of rank or hierarchy was introduced by King Cyrus the Great, which was later perfected by King Darius I (Darius the Great) (Bang & Kołodziejczyk, 2012). Farazmand (1998) suggests that the aspect of kingship and the unchanging social hierarchy, together with cosmic centralism of the supreme ruler, was underlined by the visual syntax at Persepolis. Before the Persians had started expanding their empire, the news of their justice system and military power had spread everywhere. Whenever the army of Persia arrived in a new land, it brought hope to the people living there: a judicial system, an organized governing system, military power, and a sense of security and

societal development in all aspects (Farazmand, 1998). The ability to execute large-scale projects, including operational and organizational management, capital projects, and other major initiatives, was the central feature of the Persian Achaemenid bureaucracy (Farazmand, 1998).

As the empire grew larger, King Cyrus divided the empire into separate provinces called satrapies. The Persians had followed both centralized and decentralized forms of government to handle the vast empire and its people's needs (Farazmand, 1998). Thus, they integrated local elites into the governing system, sowing a seed in the people's minds that they, as society, were also equal to the empire and had powers too. But it was a political strategy to handle the riots and ongoing disturbance in the local society by the local people. It was evident that as long as the subjects didn't pose a threat to the monarchy, the monarchy had no issues whatsoever. Subject peoples were of diverse cultures and were united under one empire and placed upon a shared political superstructure, but not all were equal and uniform (Farazmand, 1998). Thus, through a sense of being under a shared political power, the Persians intended to unite the people in their empire, which they partially succeeded, but it did not create a uniform culture or ideology.

Meanwhile, in ancient Greek civilization, it was mostly non-monarchical, except for a few cities like Sparta. Even though the Greeks and the Athenian society were smaller, they formed an elaborate and detailed system of political institutions (Lyttkens, 2010). The Greek society valued active citizen participation and thus trusted the political institutions to make changes in society. Lyttkens (2010) proposes that political reforms worked in Athens because leaders had to make promises to people that they could put their faith in. Thus, political stability depended on chosen leaders who would make these promises to people and follow through on these promises to different diverse groups of people living in the society.

Black (2016) contends that the Greeks were the only ancient people of the civilization that had found a way out of monarchy. Athens was not ruled by one man, but by the people who governed it through taking turns each year (Black, 2016). This statement proves the sense of equality that the people had in not being ruled by a monarchy, but by themselves. Shared decision-making was considered more viable than being ruled by a single person and having a hierarchy of royal bloodlines. Carugati, Hadfield, and Weingast (2015) state that in Athens, there was a formal written law and judicial system, and access to these was regulated under

written legal procedures. This gave them power in realizing their worth as citizens and as members of society.

Philosophical Aspect

Farazmand (1998) argues that royal titles were presented as rulers of all lands and the people within them, as they were chosen by the divine power and given the responsibility to extend order and mitigate chaos. As the king was considered chosen by divinity, people were imbued with the idea that an agent of divine order ruled them. Thus, the people of the empire followed the kings or rulers who ruled them. The subjects had portrayed their kings as just rulers who would punish the revolutionaries and demand obedience. The Assyrian and Persian empire was seen as monolithic autocracies that responded to rebellions only through violence, supported by their own subjective self-representations that were handed down in the state propaganda (Farazmand, 1998).

The imperial order subjects its people to bring relief to Persepolis, which symbolizes the obedience and unquestionable authority of the hierarchy. King Cyrus advises his men not to be comfortable in the fertile territories, as harsh countries create strong and powerful men who are free, while soft countries create soft men (Munson, 2009). The Persian kings viewed themselves as strong, just, and powerful men who ought to rule over the vast empire. They had the reflection that they had the right and were morally superior to rule over others. The monarchy believed the philosophical justification for their ruling the people was their natural outcome of being strong, big, and worthy men. It was evident from their philosophical idea that strong men deserved to rule and enjoy luxury while weak men were mandated to servitude.

On the other hand, Greek civilization followed the laws. Black (2016) argues that according to the law, the citizens of the city-states were asked to “rule and be ruled” (p. 133). It demonstrates that people of Athens were keen to follow the law and be under an order. Not only that, they like to be united and work accordingly, not to emphasize the need of a few over the need of the many. It was evident from their beliefs that the true purpose of the government was to prioritize the common interest rather than the self-interest of a few men.

Jech (2017) claims that to know whether a relationship is one of domination or ideal, people should be able to look one another in the eye without fear of being punished or pushed to servitude. The people of Athens found it suitable for them to be under a rule that allowed them to roam freely in society without having any reason for fear or deference. They chose to have equal rights rather than being in servitude to a king of the monarchy

Role and Position of Women

In the Persian empire, women were valued upon their status and nobility. The higher the status, the more respect and obedience they'll get from others. Women had legal, religious, and social roles in the ancient Persian civilization. They could own land, trade with others, become priestesses in religious matters, and have influence in family matters. Abdalrahman and Qadir (2024) assert that women could work the same work as men and get the same wage; some would even be given tougher jobs, such as stone carving. Although the Achaemenid empire was mostly patriarchal, its main religion, Zoroastrianism, supported the idea of equal responsibility to both men and women, which was later institutionalized within the empire's constitution as law (Abdalrahman & Qadir, 2024).

The role of royal women was different than that of common women. A sense of seclusion and invisibility behind the veil was what differentiated a royal woman from a commoner. Llewellyn-Jones (2013) argues that to differentiate themselves from the vulgar common gaze, the royal women would appear less in public, which would ensure their honour as well as their male relatives. To guard their own position together with their children's place within the court hierarchy, they would remain constantly vigilant. Although the king was the most powerful member in the court, their mother's influence became tremendous during the time of the king being young or weak (Llewellyn-Jones, 2013). The women of the royal family were highly valued for nurturing the future heirs and maintaining the peace within the royal house. As the court was a family-run business at its core, the women were expected to hold the royal dynasty (Llewellyn-Jones, 2013). Moreover, the harem was an integral part of the Persian royal court as it was a space for political, social, and dynastic intentions (Llewellyn-Jones, 2013). It reflected the court's hierarchical and patriarchal structure, diving deeper into the concubine of the king in addition to his power and prestige.

In contrast to the ancient Greek civilization, women were citizens by birth but had no political rights. Black (2016) suggested that Greek dēmokratia can only function in small states where women, immigrants, and slaves were not allowed to participate in politics. The main duty of a woman was to take care of the household, take care of the children, and supervise the slaves. In Athenian society, women virtually had no protection and were like slaves except for being the property of a man (Hughes & Hughes, 1995).

Blundell (1995) argues that it was of utmost importance to Greek fathers that their daughters ought to be virgins until marriage and should be able to give birth. By this statement, the purpose of being a woman falls only in being married off and giving birth. They had little to less freedom and had limited ability to own property. The only time they could cross from their household into the public sphere was through religion, serving as priestesses and performing rituals for which they were acknowledged (Blundell, 1995).

Conclusion

In conclusion, both the Achaemenid Persian and the Greek civilizations had their own way of ruling. The kings and the chosen governor were given the power to rule over others, maintaining order and discipline, and serving the state. What might be an acceptable ruling in a monarchy might not be convenient in a non-monarchic civilization. The Persian empire had justified its hierarchy and divine mandate through practicing a centralized monarchy. They have built a system in which only royal women and the strong could live in luxury, only when within the power structure and under the narrative of divine power to support the cosmic order. Furthermore, the Athenian society justified its non-monarchial form of government by actively participating in choosing a ruler who would make promises for them and living as equals among the society under the law, but at the cost of women not being on equal footing with the men. Thus, the comparison attests to a fundamental gap in maintaining control over people and their commitment to social equity.

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